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Android users have a strange relationship with backup. On paper, the system has never been more capable. Google now lets you back up Android device data directly through Google services, and its official Android help pages make the process sound pleasingly straightforward: open Settings, go to Google services > All services, and turn Backup on for Photos & videos, Device data, or both. Google also notes that a Google backup can take up to 24 hours to complete, and once your data is saved, the selected categories show as “On.” That is the reassuring version of the story.

The real version is messier. Many people assume Android backup is already covering everything important, when in reality their photos may be backing up to one account, device data to another, WhatsApp to yet another, and random folders like Downloads, Camera exports, Telegram saves, and scanned documents may not be protected the way they think.

Done properly, Android can be one of the easiest mobile platforms to protect. Done lazily, it becomes a scattered arrangement of half-finished sync jobs and heroic assumptions.

The first thing to understand is that Google device backup and Google Photos backup are related, but not identical. In